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Americans Being Exposed To Chemicals In Our Food

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NORAH O'DONNELL: We want to turn now to part two in our series on the safety of America's food.

There's a long list of chemicals and additives that are allowed in the U.S., but are banned in Europe and other places over health concerns.

CBS' Ben Tracy goes in-depth to look at the effort in one state to make what every American eats safer.

(Begin VT)

BEN TRACY (voiceover): Cristina Ochoa often worries if the food she's feeding her two young kids is safe--

CRISTINA OCHOA (Mother): A lot of salt.

BEN TRACY: -- even after carefully reading ingredient labels.

CRISTINA OCHOA: Some ingredients, I have no idea what they are, how to pronounce them. I want the best for my children. And I would think that, as a society, we want the best for our children.

BEN TRACY: There are more than 10,000 chemicals and additives allowed in food in the U.S., often in small amounts, but many have not been evaluated by the FDA in decades. The majority are safe, but some chemicals allowed here have been banned overseas after research has linked them to cancer and developmental or behavioral issues.

REPRESENTATIVE JAN SCHAKOWSKY (D-Illinois): We need to put the F back into the Food and Drug Administration.

BEN TRACY: Congresswoman Jan Schakowsky introduced a bill requiring the FDA to review certain chemicals that are banned overseas and to close what's known as the GRAS loophole, chemicals generally recognized as safe. This allows companies to skip an extensive safety review when adding many new chemicals to food.

Is the food industry basically policing itself?

REPRESENTATIVE JAN SCHAKOWSKY: I would say yes. And, when you look around the world and you see what they -- other countries are doing to protect their consumers, we are far behind.

BEN TRACY: CBS News has obtained a copy of proposed legislation in California that would make it the first U.S. state to ban five common chemicals, including potassium bromate, from all foods sold, distributed or made there.

STATE REPRESENTATIVE JESSE GABRIEL (D-California): They're going to have to change their recipes, get rid of these chemicals. And, hopefully, that's something that's going to have impacts far beyond our borders here in the state of California.

BEN TRACY: Cristina Ochoa says the FDA needs to do more.

CRISTINA OCHOA: We're trusting them. And this is the food that is feeding our future. And I want them to be held to a higher standard.

(End VT)

BEN TRACY: Now, in response, the FDA tells us their scientists keep up to date on food safety research, but it says it's also the responsibility of the food industry to make sure the substances they use are safe -- Norah,

NORAH O'DONNELL: Ben Tracy with that eye-opening report, thank you.

Well, we have important information for parents about another baby formula recall. What you need to know, that is next.

(ANNOUNCEMENTS)

NORAH O'DONNELL: We have an important consumer report tonight about a popular brand powdered baby formula.

About 145,000 cans of Enfamil ProSobee Simply Plant-Based Infant Formula are being called because -- recalled because they can be contaminated with a dangerous bacteria. So far, no illnesses have been reported. The recall affects cans with an expiration of March 1, 2024. Customers can return the formula where it was purchased for a full refund.

Tonight, investigators are looking into the cause of the deadly explosion that rocked an industrial area on north of Miami. Two people were killed and three injured in the blast and subsequent fire. Video from the scene shows several vehicles, including a tanker truck, in flames.

An intruder bolted into the runway of a major South Florida airport. Well, we're going to tell you how it ended.

That's next.

(ANNOUNCEMENTS)

NORAH O'DONNELL: Sheriff's deputies respond to a bizarre incident this afternoon at Florida's Fort Lauderdale-Hollywood International Airport.

Police say a man hopped the fence and ran onto the runway. The intruder, who appeared to be limping, was quickly taken into custody, and there were no significant flight disruptions.

It is Mardi Gras, or Fat Tuesday, and the streets of New Orleans are packed tonight with revelers. Parades and floats started at 8:00 a.m., and the good times will roll into the night. By late this afternoon, crowds by the thousands lined the streets of the French Quarter, enjoying what's called the biggest party in the year.

We found a political memorabilia collector's dream in former President Jimmy Carter's hometown of Plains, Georgia. That story is next.

(ANNOUNCEMENTS)

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